

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Building Your Network

1. Adopt the Right Mindset

- ☐ Treat networking as an **exchange of value**, not extraction.
- ☐ Assume it will take **consistent effort over time**.
- ☐ Focus on being **useful to others**, not just getting help.
- ☐ **Respect** people's **time** and social capital.

2. Clarify Your Networking Goals

- ☐ Identify current challenges where an outside perspective would help.
- ☐ Define 1-2 specific learning goals (e.g., org design, pricing, hiring).
- ☐ Prioritize relationships aligned to what you're actively learning.

3. Leverage Your Network Effectively

Use your network for:

- ☐ Benchmarking team sizes and org structure.
- ☐ Vendor pricing and renewal negotiation insights.
- ☐ Sensitive executive-team advice.
- ☐ Compensation calibration and market signals.
- ☐ Job market and career move perspective.
- ☐ Backchannel references on senior hires.

After receiving help:

- ☐ Share outcomes and context on what worked.
- ☐ Thank them and acknowledge specific advice.

4. Build Your Network Intentionally

A. Work Together (High-Leverage Path)

- ☐ Spend time at a fast-growing company in a major tech hub (if early career).
- ☐ Invest in strong peer relationships while working together.

B. Cold Outreach (Done Well)

- ☐ Reach out to “near network” contacts (mutual connections).
- ☐ Keep messages to 2–4 concise sentences.
- ☐ Ask **one clear, specific question**.
- ☐ Avoid vague asks like “Can we chat?”
- ☐ Do not demand time; offer flexibility instead.
- ☐ Avoid repeated follow-ups if there is no reply.
- ☐ Reuse effective outreach templates thoughtfully.

5. Consider Community Building

- ☐ Join or create a small, curated peer learning circle.
- ☐ Select thoughtful, strong communicators.
- ☐ Establish a code of conduct.
- ☐ Commit to maintaining and operating the group.
- ☐ Prefer small, private groups for executive-level discussions.

6. Be Realistic About Large Communities

- ☐ Use large forums to learn broadly.

- ☐ Avoid sharing sensitive executive details publicly.
- ☐ Don't expect high-quality advice on complex issues in open spaces.
- ☐ Remember: easier access often means lower signal.

7. Be Strategic About Writing & Speaking

- ☐ Write or speak publicly if you enjoy it.
- ☐ Don't rely on content creation as your primary networking strategy.
- ☐ Weigh time investment vs. direct outreach and events.

8. Avoid Common Mistakes

- ☐ Avoid vague time-based asks ("grab some time to chat?").
- ☐ Avoid confusing or multi-part requests.
- ☐ Avoid asking for introductions without clear mutual value.
- ☐ Don't overconsume others' communities without contributing.
- ☐ If outreach isn't working, get feedback on your approach.

9. Build Other Critical Networks

Founders

- ☐ Build relationships with founders for perspective.
- ☐ Connect through startups or angel investing (if appropriate).
- ☐ Seek the founder's advice if navigating founder dynamics.

Venture Capitalists

- ☐ Build pattern-level relationships with VCs.
- ☐ Ask portfolio-level or industry-pattern questions.
- ☐ Use CEO/board connections to meet a few trusted VCs.

Executive Recruiters

- ☐ Build relationships before you need a job.
- ☐ Connect during hiring cycles.
- ☐ Maintain periodic light-touch contact.

10. Maintain a Sustainable Rhythm

- ☐ Set a modest goal (e.g., meet 1 new person per month).
- ☐ Track who you've connected with.
- ☐ Follow up periodically with useful context or updates.
- ☐ Keep networking important—but not your top priority.